the mid-twelfth century. As also noted above, however, the contemporary authors examined historical vicissitudes while adhering to "historiographical expectations." The unidirectional linearity of hindsight, for example, is a characteristic to be borne in mind for *all* court chronicles (and no less for modern scholarship), which at least partly explains the inclusions *and* exclusions of events from textual narratives. The historical authors' investments – to varying degrees – in highlighting their royal patrons in the greater flow of history (such as it was conceived), and in "bending" the constitutive events *a posteriori* into a concatenation, ultimately resulted in the fabrication of a historical arc with a beginning, an apogee, and a *dénouement*.

It comes as little surprise, then, that the known texts – including Juzjani's *Tabaqat* – leave many unknowns for the period of this volume's focus on the early Shansabanis in modern Afghanistan and Pakistan, that is, prior to their entry into the north Indian *duab*. Partly in response to this historiographical state of affairs, one of the fundamental premises of this two-volume project is that architecture and material culture – especially archaeological finds and numismatics – serve as indispensable *primary* sources supplying evidentiary data, both enriching and at times apparently contradicting their textual counterparts.

In the fifth and sixth decades of the twelfth century, the Shansabanis' star seemed to rise steadily: their sphere of influence had rapidly extended beyond their encampments and/or seasonal settlements in historical Ghur. It is unclear precisely what prompted 'Izz al-Din's (*c.*1100–1146 CE) third son Saif al-Din (*c.*1146–1149)[55] to divide the ancestral territories – likely definable by areas of transhumance and cultivation patterns (i.e., pastures, agricultural areas, and dwellings[56]) – among his six brothers and himself (Genealogy, p. xvii). But it would not be unfounded to suggest that a role was played therein by customary laws governing property inheritance in some nomadic societies, observable among modern groups.[57]

With the Ghaznavids and – especially after their defeat at Dandanqan in AH 432/1040 CE – the Saljuqs both being distant powers whose authority was manifest principally at important regional centers such as Zaranj (Sistan),[58] Herat, and Balkh, Ghur's internal developments progressed with only rare outside intervention.[59] The overall outcome was a rapid, multi-directional expansion of Shansabani dominion far beyond the parameters of their seasonal transhumance (map, p. xvi), with a nominal recognition of the larger powers' suzerainty expressed mainly through tribute and ceremonial acknowledgment, for example, in the *khutba* and on coinage. Concurrently, the Shansabanis fractured into a loose confederacy of independent lineages based at Firuzkuh, Bamiyan, and ultimately Ghazna (see Chapters 3–5).

Juzjani's consistent implication of the paramountcy of the Shansabanis at Firuzkuh was surely overlaid on familial–political contestations. Some